

Social and cultural traditions surrounding coffee consumption

Coffee culture describes a social atmosphere or series of associated social behaviors that depends heavily upon coffee, particularly as a social lubricant. The term refers to the cultural patterns and norms surrounding the consumption of coffee, particularly as a social activity.

Coffee originated in Ethiopia, where legend tells of a goat herder named Kaldi who discovered coffee when he noticed his goats became energized after eating berries from a certain tree. By the 15th century, coffee was being cultivated in Yemen, and by the 16th century, it had spread to Persia, Egypt, Syria, and Turkey. Coffeehouses became important social and cultural centers in the Ottoman Empire. The first coffeehouse opened in Constantinople in 1554. These establishments became known as 'schools of the wise' where people gathered to drink coffee, listen to music, play chess, and discuss current affairs. European coffee culture developed differently in various countries. Italian espresso bars, Viennese coffeehouses, Parisian cafés, and British coffee shops each developed distinct traditions. Viennese coffee culture, with its grand coffeehouses and tradition of reading newspapers while sipping coffee, was even inscribed on UNESCO's list of intangible cultural heritage. The modern specialty coffee movement, often called 'third-wave coffee', emerged in the late 20th century. This movement treats coffee as an artisanal foodstuff rather than a commodity. It emphasizes high-quality beans, lighter roasting, and sophisticated brewing methods. Single-origin coffees and detailed tasting notes have become standard.

Coffee has played a role in social and political movements throughout history. Coffeehouses in 17th-century England became centers for political discussion and debate. Lloyd's of London began as a coffeehouse. The American Revolution was partly planned in coffeehouses. Different cultures have developed unique coffee preparations. Turkish coffee is brewed unfiltered and served with the grounds. Italian espresso forms the basis for cappuccino and latte. Vietnamese iced coffee combines strong coffee with sweetened condensed milk. Ethiopian coffee ceremonies are elaborate social rituals. Today, coffee is the world's second-most traded commodity after oil. Global coffee culture continues to evolve, with sustainability, fair trade, and direct relationships between roasters and farmers becoming increasingly important considerations in the industry.